about the election of veteran Ghanshyam Tiwari. The 75-year-old has had a bit of a zigzag political trajectory: he had floated his own party after acrimoniously resigning from the BJP in 2018, but lost his deposit from home turf Sanganer in the assembly polls. He then joined the Congress, before rejoining the BJP. His selection disappointed those expected the party to groom a younger leader. In another move that left even prominent BJP leaders like former CM Vasundhara Raje and leader of the opposition Gulab Chand Kataria bewildered, the party backed media moghul Subhash Chandra as an independent

GEHLOT CREATED PANIC IN THE BJP. IT, TOO, MOVED MLAS TO A HOTEL

for the second seat.

Against every indication, Chandra kept claiming that as many as eight Congress MLAs would cross-vote in his favour. Gehlot, who has learnt from the Sachin Pilot-led rebellion that nearly overthrew his government around the Rajya Sabha polls in 2020, moved his MLAs to a five-star luxury hotel in Udaipur, before bringing them to Jaipur for the polling. Gehlot has so far kept his MLAs in hotels for nearly 1,250 hours—wags have now named his government 'Resort Raj Luxurious'.

To be fair to him, Gehlot had little choice but to keep his flock corralled. He knows most non-Congress MLAs who saved his government in 2020, like the independents, are upset because the party high command, on Pilot's advice, did not reward them. But his negotiating skills paid off as six BSP-turned-Congress MLAs who were unhappy with the government were placated and two Bharatiya Tribal Party MLAs defied their party whip to vote Congress. Similarly, independent MLAs, too, supported him. "I was always sure that non-Congress MLAs who refused offers of Rs 25 crore to bring me down in 2020 will never betray me whatever the BJP offers them," Gehlot said.

As polling day drew close, Gehlot managed to create a great fear of cross-voting in the BJP camp, which also cooped up its MLAs in a luxury hotel in Jaipur. Indeed, a concerned BJP told 43 of its 71 MLAs, instead of 41, to vote for Ghanshyam Tiwari, just to be safe. That scuppered Chandra's chances, and he left Jaipur before results were announced.

Gehlot's adroit management skills will fortify his position with the high command. Also, he is bound to reward his loyalists with tickets and sops before the 2023 assembly polls in Rajasthan. It's left for the BJP to take stock of its Rajasthan unit. Under state unit chief Satish Poonia, it has lost five of the six assembly byelections. The BJP top brass will have to decide if it wants to go ahead with Poonia or bring Vasundhara Raje back at the helm. ■

UTTAR PRADESH

HIGH HANGING SUMMER FRUIT

By Prashant Srivastava

Mohammed Tariq Khan can scarcely believe his eyes. Owner of mango orchards in one of India's great centres of the fruit—Malihabad tehsil of Lucknow district, where the luscious Dashehri mangoes originate—the 56-year-old daily checks on the progress of the fruit under his watch, but returns a dispirited man each evening. His harvest is wilting. Production of mangoes has plummeted in singular and spectacular fashion this year in Uttar Pradesh, by as much as a staggering 80-85 per cent. Tariq is one of those crippled by the losses: he has not even been able to pay salaries to labourers. Thousands of growers in UP's mango belts are unable to cover their cost too—leave alone making a profit. The inevitable corollary for the consumer: prices are expected to soar this summer.

UP's wide open Gangetic flatlands normally yield some 35-45 lakh metric tonnes of mangoes every year. This year, that figure has dropped sharply—to a mere 10-12 lakh metric tonnes. According to growers, this sorry state was mostly brought about by extreme and erratic weather conditions—especially the repeated heat waves. They also blame inferior quality pesticides. Other regions are suffering too, but nowhere is the crisis deeper than in Malihabad—the largest of UP's 14 mango belts, which usually manages to delight countless palates with the Chausa, Safeda and Lucknowa varieties as well as the Dashehri. Mango orchards cover some 30,000 hectares in the tehsil, and it has some of the oldest mango trees. The groves here are owned by families who have been in the business for generations, sometimes for 100-200 years.

"It's the lowest yield that I have ever seen in Malihabad and other mango belts of Uttar Pradesh," says Insram Ali, president, All India